

Ontological Vertigo

The Apprehension of Asymmetric Dependence

A patristic, Thomistic, and mystical study

How received existence has been reasoned, confessed,
and contemplatively apprehended across the centuries

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1 The Sudden Weight of “Is”

A fact can be known for years and then change its weight. One has always known, in some loose sense, that one did not cause one’s own birth. The sharper recognition is present-tense: *I do not originate or sustain the act by which I exist now*. My existence is genuinely mine, but it is not from me.

That recognition differs from ordinary dependence. A body depends on oxygen; a child depends on parents; a city depends on farms, roads, laws, and trust. Such relations may be temporary, partial, or reciprocal. Ontological dependence reaches beneath them. It concerns not first what helps a thing flourish, but what accounts for there being an actual thing with powers that can flourish at all.

The word *vertigo* is therefore metaphorical. Nothing begins to spin, and no feeling proves a metaphysical conclusion. The term names an intellectual apprehension that may carry an affective recoil: the familiar self remains solidly real, yet loses the imagined status of being self-grounded. The abyss is not empty space beneath the world. It is the creature’s inability to supply its own act of being.

Governing thesis

Ontological vertigo is the apprehension of asymmetric dependence: the recognition that a creature is wholly real and genuinely active, yet neither originates nor sustains the act by which it exists, while the uncreated source depends upon it in no corresponding ontological way.

Four claims are joined in that sentence. The dependence is *present*, not merely a fact about a remote beginning. It is *asymmetric*: the effect requires the source in the order of being, while the source does not require the effect. It is *noncompetitive*: the source of a creature’s existence does not replace the creature’s own powers. And it is *ontological*, not a diagnosis of emotional need or social helplessness.

The governing sentence is this article’s synthesis; the realities it gathers are inherited. They have appeared under a long succession of terms: participation, act and potency, creation from nothing, conservation, received existence, primary and secondary causality, divine presence, and contemplative unknowing. The history matters because each term protects the insight from a different distortion.

2 The Ancient Grammar: Participation and Act

Christian metaphysics did not begin with an empty vocabulary. Plato and Aristotle supplied questions and distinctions that later thinkers would receive, criticize, and transform.

In the *Republic*, Plato places the Good beyond the objects whose truth and being it makes intelligible (VI, 508e–509b). In the *Timaeus*, whatever comes to be requires a cause, and the ordered cosmos points toward a maker looking to an intelligible model (27d–29b). These texts establish a vertical grammar: what appears does not contain the whole account of its intelligibility or actuality. Yet Plato’s Good is not simply the God of Christian doctrine, and the *Timaeus* does not state creation from nothing. To read either claim back into the dialogue would erase the very development a history should explain.

Aristotle makes a second advance. Change is the passage from potency to act; what is merely potential cannot, in that same respect, actualize itself. In *Metaphysics* XII.6–7, the order of motion requires an eternal actuality that moves without being moved. Aristotle can therefore say that heaven and nature depend upon a first principle. But his eternal cosmos, celestial movers, and account of final causality are not yet Aquinas’s free universal Creator.

Christian thinkers would transform this inheritance by asking not only how change requires actuality, but how every finite substance receives the whole of its being. Scripture and the contests over matter, necessity, and the status of the Word supplied the pressure under which that question became unmistakably Christian.

3 The Fathers: Life That Does Not Arise from Us

3.1 Begun and continued by another

Irenaeus gives an early, unusually direct account. Against the claim that a soul must be unbegotten in order to endure, he distinguishes God, who alone is without beginning, from everything made. Created things begin and continue as long as God wills them to exist. The soul is not life itself but participates in life bestowed by God; “life does not arise from us” (*Against Heresies* II.34.2–4). His immediate subject is the soul’s duration, not a later scholastic theory of *esse*. Still, the asymmetry is plain: continuance is conferred; the giver does not receive continuance from the recipient.

Athanasius sharpens the Creator–creature distinction against both spontaneous origin and formation from coeternal matter. God makes the universe from nothing through the Word and grants existence from goodness (*On the Incarnation* 3). In *Against the Heathen* 40–42, the Word also orders and preserves the created whole. Human beings are mutable creatures; incorruption is not native to humanity but a gift. Athanasius’s language of corruption and return toward non-being also serves his account of sin and redemption, so it should not be flattened into a single metaphysical formula. Its governing judgment remains: the Word is not one fragile participant among others. He is the divine giver through whom creatures are called into being and held in order.

3.2 More inward than the self

Augustine turns the same dependence inward. At the opening of the *Confessions* he asks how he could exist unless God were in him, then corrects the direction: rather, unless he were in God (I.2.2). He later calls God more inward than his inmost self and higher than his highest part (III.6.11). This is not pantheism. In Book VII he rejects the thought that God is a spatial substance spread through the world, then apprehends the immutable Light above his mutable mind (VII.1.1–2; 10.16–11.17). Divine transcendence and divine intimacy intensify together: the cause of being is not a part enclosed within the creature, yet no created cause is present at a deeper explanatory level.

Dependence is no longer only a proposition about the cosmos. The inquirer discovers it within the act of inquiry. The mind that judges mutable things by truth is itself mutable; the life by which it seeks God is already upheld. Augustine describes the encounter with both trembling and love. The response is not evidence added to a weak argument. It is what can occur when the argument’s object is apprehended as the present condition of the knower’s own existence.

The Fathers establish the Christian field Aquinas will later articulate more exactly: one uncreated God, creatures called from nothing, the Word as creator rather than creature, created duration as gift, and a divine presence that does not dissolve the distinction between giver and recipient.

4 The Thomistic Center: A Relation with Weight on One Side

4.1 Existence received under a limit

Aquinas supplies the paper’s central grammar. A finite thing has an essence: a definite way of being this kind of thing rather than another. But knowing what a human, oak, or angel is does not yet show that such a thing exists. That epistemic difference is not itself the demonstration. Aquinas further argues that whatever possesses existence without being existence itself receives it from another; creatures possess caused existence according to a limited nature (ST I, q. 3, a. 4; q. 44, a. 1; *De ente et essentia*, ch. 4).

The first universal cause cannot receive the actuality it ultimately explains. Aquinas therefore identifies God not as one being with an unusually secure possession of existence, but as subsistent being itself, *ipsum esse subsistens*. This is a Thomistic conclusion, not a definition imposed on every Catholic school. Its force here is precise: creatures have being by participation; God does not participate in a more basic actuality. If God received existence, the regress would not have reached its source.

4.2 Creation as a real relation in the creature

Aquinas makes the asymmetry explicit in the language of relation. Creation, considered passively, places in the creature a real relation to the Creator as the principle of its being (ST I, q. 45, a. 3). The creature's very condition is *from another*. In God, however, creation adds no accident, perfection, or change. The divine act is identical with the simple divine being; the new term is the creature.

His earlier treatment of divine names states the pattern with still greater clarity. God is outside the whole order of creation; creatures are really ordered to him, not he to them in the same ontological order (ST I, q. 13, a. 7). Aquinas accordingly calls the relation creature-to-God real and the corresponding relation in God a relation of reason.

"Of reason" does not mean fictional. God really knows, wills, creates, preserves, and loves creatures. The phrase denies that creation installs in God a dependent feature by which God becomes more actual. The name "Creator" is newly true when creatures exist, but no intrinsic divine alteration has occurred. The ontological weight lies on one side: the creature is constituted as an effect; God is not constituted as God by producing it.

4.3 Conservation is not an ancient event

Creation in Aquinas's strict usage includes the creature's origin and newness. Present dependence is treated directly under conservation. An agent may cause only a thing's becoming, as a builder builds a house that afterward stands through the properties of its materials. The universal cause of being is different. Every creature depends on God precisely for being, and therefore cannot subsist apart from the divine conserving action (ST I, q. 104, a. 1).

Aquinas uses light in air as an analogy. Air is genuinely illuminated, but its light does not become self-rooted through duration; it remains dependent on the illuminating source. The comparison has limits—God is not a physical emitter and conservation is not a sequence of repairs. Aquinas says that the conserving action continues the action by which God gives existence, without motion or time (q. 104, a. 1, ad 4). The counterfactual "without this action the creature would not be" states an explanatory dependence. It does not picture an intermittent God deciding from moment to moment whether to resume.

The conclusion is substantive, not true by definition. An objector may treat finite existence as a brute fact or claim that, once produced, it persists without a cause of its being. Aquinas answers that the universal cause gives the act of being that no creature possesses by essence (q. 104, a. 1). This paper adopts that Thomistic account; the possible feeling of vertigo supplies no missing premise and does not make disagreement irrational.

The thesis can now be stated without metaphor. Every creature receives and is presently conserved in the act by which it exists; the first cause receives its act from neither the creature nor another. The dependence is therefore ontological and asymmetric.

5 Dependence without Rivalry

Total dependence sounds, at first, as though it must leave the creature with nothing to do. That conclusion follows only if divine and created causes compete on the same plane, like two hands trying to move one lever. Aquinas denies the premise.

God gives creatures not only existence but definite natures and powers. Fire heats, parents generate, physicians heal, intellects understand, and wills choose. When God works in every agent, the agent's proper operation is not suppressed; it is grounded (ST I, q. 105, a. 5). Even conservation can employ ordered created causes while God remains the principal cause (q. 104, a. 2). The creature is not less real because its dependence is more radical. It can act in its own right precisely because the Creator causes it to be the kind of cause it is.

This distinction protects both metaphysics and science. A biochemical account of breathing, a neurological account of perception, and a historical account of a decision can each be true at its own level. Divine causality is not inserted where empirical explanation fails. It concerns the actual existence and operation of every cause that empirical inquiry succeeds in identifying.

Five confusions excluded

- *Not deism*: the Creator is not merely a remote starter; creatures are presently conserved.
- *Not occasionalism*: created causes possess and exercise real powers.
- *Not pantheism*: dependence does not make creatures parts, modes, or pieces of the divine substance.
- *Not chronology alone*: even a hypothetically beginningless creature would depend for being.
- *Not psychological incapacity*: ontological dependence is compatible with mature agency, responsibility, and courage.

The Catechism later joins the two sides without embarrassment. God upholds creatures “at every moment” and enables them to act (CCC 301); he also grants them the dignity of being causes and principles for one another (CCC 306–308). The same doctrine that denies creaturely aseity establishes creaturely agency.

This is why humility is the appropriate intellectual virtue, but humiliation is the wrong conclusion. Humility tells the truth about a power that is real and received. Humiliation would treat received reality as counterfeit. The asymmetric relation permits neither self-creation nor self-erasure.

6 When the Proposition Becomes an Apprehension

The metaphysical judgment and the mystical reception of it must be distinguished. A contemplative experience cannot repair an invalid inference, and no particular sensation is promised to one who understands the argument. Yet the mystics describe what happens when dependence is apprehended not only as a universal statement but as the truth of this living subject before God.

Gregory Nazianzen first disciplines the movement. From created order the mind may know that God is, but the divine nature cannot be circumscribed by a creaturely concept (*Oration* 28.4–6). The ascent repeatedly discovers an unattained depth. This does not cancel knowledge; it distinguishes true causal knowledge from comprehension. If the source is not a member of the created order, intellectual success must include the knowledge that the source exceeds the mode of its effects.

That limit acquires affective form in Augustine. Before the eternal Wisdom through whom creatures are made, he compresses the response into two verbs, *inhorresco et inardesco*: he shudders insofar as he is unlike that Wisdom and burns insofar as he is like it (*Confessions* XI.9.11). The two responses belong together. Dependence marks an immeasurable difference, while created likeness makes knowledge and desire possible.

Pseudo-Dionysius gives the same limit a systematic shape. In *Divine Names* V, beings receive their existence from the cause that precedes and exceeds being as creatures possess it. In *Mystical Theology* I, affirmation is followed by negation and eminence: God is not captured by any created predicate. Dionysian darkness is not a blank into which any claim may be projected. It is the failure of finite comprehension before excess, after causal affirmations have done their work.

A later image makes dependence visible at once. In the fifth chapter of Julian of Norwich’s *Revelations of Divine Love*, creation appears in her hand as a tiny thing, about the size of a hazelnut, frail enough to seem liable to fall into nothing. She understands three facts: God made it, loves it, and keeps it. The image does no independent work as a proof. Its force is apprehensive. The universe that abstract discourse calls “all created being” is seen at once as real, little, conserved, and loved.

Yet conservation is not sanctifying union. In *Ascent of Mount Carmel* II.5.3–4, John of the Cross distinguishes God’s substantial presence, by which every creature is preserved in the being it has, from the transforming union of the soul with God by likeness of love. The first belongs to creaturehood as such; the second is a union of grace and charity. A sinner does not cease to depend ontologically on God, and a saint does not cease to be a creature when united to God.

Bernard of Clairvaux shows why asymmetry need not mean isolation. In *Sermons on the Song of Songs* 83.4–6, the creature’s love answers the Creator’s, though not on equal terms—*etsi non ex aequo*. Love returns toward its source while continuing to draw from that source. The response can be wholly the creature’s without becoming underived or equal in mode.

This prevents mystical language from consuming metaphysics. “Union” is not identity of essence. “Nothingness” is not the denial that creatures are good and real. “Darkness” is not ignorance made authoritative. The mystics intensify the asymmetry while keeping both terms: the uncreated giver and the created recipient, joined without being confused.

Ontological vertigo, in this register, is the possible recoil of the whole person before a proposition whose subject is oneself: I am, but not from myself.

7 The Insight after the Scholastics

The recognition did not disappear when medieval vocabulary ceased to govern philosophy. In the Third Meditation, Descartes argues that past existence does not by itself account for present existence. Preservation and creation differ only conceptually in the respect under discussion: a cause is required not only for the self’s production but for its conservation now. His larger method and metaphysics differ sharply from Aquinas’s, but the present tense of dependence survives.

The Catholic doctrinal boundary was stated with particular force in the nineteenth century. Vatican I confesses a God really and essentially distinct from the world, freely creating not to acquire or increase divine beatitude but to manifest perfection through goods given to creatures (*Dei Filius*, ch. 1). When the constitution turns to faith, it says that the human person wholly depends on God as Creator and Lord (ch. 3). The council defines the Creator–creature distinction and free creation; it does not canonize every Thomistic explanation used in this paper.

The *Catechism of the Catholic Church* gives the contemporary synthesis. God is at once infinitely greater than his works and present to their inmost being (CCC 300). He sustains them at every moment, enables their action, and orders them to their end (CCC 301). This “utter dependence” is named a source not only of wisdom but of freedom, joy, and confidence. The next articles safeguard secondary causality and human cooperation.

Across these changes of idiom, the constant is not one image or proof. It is a structure: finite actuality does not explain itself; dependence reaches the present; the source is not reciprocally dependent; and the received act is sufficiently real to ground genuine action. The phrase *asymmetric dependence* is contemporary. The structure it names is old.

8 What the Vertigo Sees

The apprehension changes no physical object. The page remains paper. The reader remains a responsible secondary cause, able to attend or turn away. What changes is the tacit picture of possession. Existence is no longer treated as the one possession preceding every gift; it is recognized as the first received condition of every other good.

This recognition does not settle every dispute about metaphysical demonstration, providence, suffering, or divine action. It does establish what the thesis means. The creature is neither self-grounded nor unreal. Its dependence is total in the order of being, while its nature, powers, and acts are genuinely its own. God is really their source without receiving actuality from them.

There is sobriety in this conclusion. Gratitude becomes more exact, because the gift is not merely something added to an independently existing recipient. Humility becomes metaphysical rather than theatrical, because it refuses both self-invention and self-contempt. Freedom ceases to mean the impossible power to be one’s own cause.

The vertigo is not the fear that nothing holds. It is the apprehension that everything created is held, and that the One who holds it is not held by it.

A Scope, Method, and Qualifications

A.1 Reader, question, and method

This is a discursive metaphysical and spiritual-theological article for a serious general reader. It asks what the phrase “ontological vertigo is the apprehension of asymmetric dependence” can mean within a Catholic and specifically Thomistic account of creation, and how related judgments have appeared from ancient philosophy through patristic, scholastic, mystical, and modern Catholic witnesses.

The phrase is the article’s governing synthesis; it is not attributed to an earlier author and is not offered as a standard technical definition. “Apprehension” means an intellectual judgment reflexively grasped as true of oneself. “Vertigo” names its possible affective resonance. The feeling neither proves the judgment nor indicates sanctity, infused contemplation, private revelation, or a state of grace.

Source class	Function in the article	Governing boundary
Ancient philosophy	Supplies participation, ontological priority, potency and act, and unmoved actuality.	Plato and Aristotle are neither made implicit Christians nor credited with creation from nothing or Thomistic conservation.
Sacred Scripture	Governs creation through the Word, divine sustaining presence, and the goodness and preservation of creatures.	Short working-English phrases do not turn one biblical locus into a scholastic proof.
Conciliar and catechetical teaching	Governs one free Creator, real distinction from the world, total creaturely dependence, providence, and genuine secondary causality.	Dogmatic and authoritative boundaries do not canonize every Thomistic step in the article.
Patristic witness	Supplies creation from nothing, continuance by divine will, preservation through the Word, divine intimacy, and apophatic restraint.	Later terms are not retroactively placed in a Father’s text; breadth is not an authority count.
Thomistic theology	Provides the principal account of essence and existence, participation, real relation, conservation, and noncompetitive causality.	The real distinction and the one-sided real relation are identified as Thomistic school metaphysics where they are not themselves dogmatic formulas.
Mystical witness	Shows dependence apprehended in wonder, trembling, love, and union without absorption.	Images and experiences illustrate reception; they do not substitute for demonstration or promise a reproducible feeling.
Project synthesis	Defines “ontological vertigo” and orders the historical material around asymmetric dependence.	The definition, phenomenology, and final formulations belong to this article, not to a cited source.

A.2 Included and excluded scope

Included are selected ancient antecedents; representative patristic accounts in Irenaeus, Athanasius, Augustine, Gregory Nazianzen, and Pseudo-Dionysius; Aquinas on participated existence, creation, conservation, relation, and primary and secondary causality; mystical reception in Julian of Norwich, John of the Cross, and Bernard of Clairvaux; Descartes’s restatement of present conservation; and the doctrinal boundaries in Vatican I and the *Catechism of the Catholic Church*.

Excluded are a comprehensive history of metaphysics; a defense of every premise against every contemporary objection; the Kalam argument and physical cosmology; a complete account of providence, evil, grace, deification, Trinitarian processions, or mystical prayer; and adjudication among Thomist, Scotist, Suárezian, Palamite, or contemporary analytic accounts of dependence. No legal, jurisdictional, or mutable disciplinary conclusion is made.

A.3 Material qualifications

1. The definition describes the Thomistic conclusion; it is not itself a demonstration. Brute-fact and “existential inertia” objections remain substantive disagreements about causal explanation.
2. The asymmetry is limited to the order of created being. It does not deny that God truly knows, wills, loves, addresses, and covenants with creatures.
3. Aquinas’s claim that the creature has a real relation to God while the corresponding relation in God is one of reason does not make divine action imaginary. It denies a received accident, perfection, or intrinsic change in the simple God.
4. Essence and existence are metaphysical principles, not two objects, a container and its contents, or a substance poured into another substance. The real distinction in creatures and *ipsum esse subsistens* are the article’s adopted Thomistic articulation.
5. Participation in being does not make a creature a fragment, mode, or material part of God. Creator and creature remain really and essentially distinct.
6. Creation, conservation, and concurrence are distinguished: total origin without presupposed matter; persistence in received being; and divine action in the operations of real secondary causes.
7. Present dependence is not a claim that God repeatedly re-creates a creature through a temporal series of decisions. God’s eternal act produces and conserves temporal effects without change in God.
8. Dependence in being is not identical with corruptibility or modal contingency. Even an incorruptible creature, or one necessary through another, possesses being from another (ST I, q. 44, a. 1, ad 2).
9. Primary causality does not reduce created causality to an appearance. The whole effect can be from God and from a creature in different causal orders.
10. Divine concurrence with a creature’s act does not make God the author of the defect that constitutes sin: God causes the act’s actuality, not its defective mode (ST I–II, q. 79, a. 2). This article does not attempt the fuller moral analysis.
11. Pseudo-Dionysius is identified according to modern convention as an anonymous late-fifth- or early-sixth-century Christian author, not as the convert of Acts 17.
12. Mystical union by grace is distinct from the sustaining divine presence common to all creatures. Neither is identity of essence.

A.4 Translations, rights, currentness, and review

Scriptural language is limited to short traditional or working-English phrases. Patristic and mystical checking used the identified public-domain ANF, NPNF, Parker, Warrack, Eales, and Lewis–Zimmerman witnesses, together with stable work and locus citations. Thomas is cited by work, question, article, chapter, and reply, with Latin checked in the Corpus Thomisticum and public English used only as a working aid. Descartes is cited by the Third Meditation. No modern copyrighted translation is reproduced.

The brief Latin phrases and all source wording remain outside the project’s CC BY 4.0 grant; the surrounding synthesis is project-created. Online witnesses were checked through 20 July 2026. The publication is an internally source-audited working study. It has not received independent philosophical, patristic, Thomistic, mystical-theological, dogmatic, literary, or ecclesiastical review and claims no ecclesiastical approval.

B References

Scripture and authoritative Catholic witnesses

- Sacred Scripture: Wis 11:24–26; John 1:1–3; Acts 17:24–28; Rom 11:36; Col 1:16–17; Heb 1:3. Short English wording is used as a working rendering; Scripture and translations retain their own status.

- First Vatican Council, dogmatic constitution *Dei Filius* (24 April 1870), chs. 1 and 3 and canons 1.3–5: the simple God really distinct from the world, free creation from nothing, divine non-need, providence, and the creature’s total dependence; official Latin.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 285, 290–301, 306–308, especially 300–301 on transcendence, intimate presence, and present sustaining action, and 306–308 on real secondary causality; official English.

Ancient philosophical antecedents

- Plato, *Republic* VI, 508e–509b, on the Good as source of intelligibility and being; *Timaeus* 27d–29b, on becoming, cause, and the cosmic craftsman. Benjamin Jowett’s public-domain English was used as a working witness at the Internet Classics Archive and Timaeus text. The article does not identify these doctrines with Christian creation.
- Aristotle, *Metaphysics* XII.6–7, 1071b3–1072b30, on actuality, the unmoved mover, and the dependence of heaven and nature; W. D. Ross’s public-domain working English, Internet Classics Archive. See also *Physics* VIII.5–6.

Patristic and late-patristic witnesses

- St. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* II.34.2–4, on God alone unbegun, created duration according to divine will, and life by participation; Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut’s 1885 ANF working English, online witness.
- St. Athanasius of Alexandria, *On the Incarnation of the Word* 3–5, on creation from nothing through the Word and creaturely mutability, NPNF working English; *Against the Heathen* 40–42, on the Word ordering and preserving the created whole, working English.
- St. Augustine of Hippo, *Confessions* I.2.2; III.6.11; VII.1.1–2 and 10.16–11.17; XI.4.6–9.11, on existence through divine presence, inwardness and transcendence, rejection of spatial extension, mutable participation, creation in the Word, and *inhorresco et inardesco*; Book I, Book III, Book VII, Book XI.
- St. Gregory Nazianzen, *Oration* 28.4–6, on knowing God’s existence from created order while failing to comprehend the divine nature; NPNF working English.
- Pseudo-Dionysius, *Divine Names* V.1–8, on the superessential cause from whom beings receive and preserve existence; *Mystical Theology* I.1–3, on affirmation, negation, and unknowing. John Parker, trans., *The Works of Dionysius the Areopagite*, vol. 1 (London: James Parker, 1897), public-domain working edition.

Thomistic framework

- St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 3, a. 4 and q. 4, a. 2 (God as his existence and subsistent being); q. 13, a. 7 (asymmetry of Creator–creature relation); q. 44, a. 1, including ad 2 (participated being, universal causality, and necessity from another); q. 45, aa. 1–3, 5 (creation and its real relation in the creature); q. 46, a. 2 (temporal beginning not naturally demonstrated); q. 104, aa. 1–2 (conservation); q. 105, aa. 4–5 (divine action in real secondary causes); I–II, q. 79, a. 2 (God causes the act’s actuality, not the defect of sin).
- Aquinas, *De ente et essentia*, ch. 4, on created essence and existence and the first cause whose essence is existence; *De potentia*, q. 3, a. 7 and q. 5, a. 1; *Summa contra Gentiles* II.15–21 and III.65–70, for creation, conservation, and the operations of secondary causes.
- Latin loci checked in the Corpus Thomisticum Leonine-text corpus; the New Advent Summa was used as a working public English index. Work, question, article, chapter, and reply control over either site’s wording.

Mystical and later witnesses

- St. Bernard of Clairvaux, *Sermons on the Song of Songs* 83.4–6, on the creature’s unequal yet whole return of love toward its source; Latin checked in *Sancti Bernardi Opera*, vol. 2, 300–302, with a stable online Latin witness; Samuel J. Eales’s 1895 English used only as a public-domain aid.
- Julian of Norwich, *Revelations of Divine Love*, long text, ch. 5, on the created whole as made, loved, and kept. Grace Warrack’s 1901 public-domain working English, CCEL edition; the image is treated as mystical apprehension, not demonstration.
- St. John of the Cross, *Ascent of Mount Carmel* II.5.3–4, distinguishing God’s sustaining substantial presence in every creature from transformative union by love. David Lewis, trans., Benedict Zimmerman, rev., *The Ascent of Mount Carmel* (London: Thomas Baker, 1906), public-domain working edition, Internet Archive scan.
- René Descartes, *Meditations on First Philosophy*, Third Meditation, on present conservation and the conceptual distinction between preservation and creation in the respect argued; public-domain Elizabeth S. Haldane translation, online witness.

C Generation Metadata

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Model: GPT-5-based Codex agent; **unexposed:** exact model identifier and model qualifiers

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (philosophical, patristic, Thomistic, mystical, theological, literary, drafting, typesetting, and visual QA roles); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; **unexposed:** server revision

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